



BaChativa

— The Bulletin —

The Weekly Bulletin of the Hashmonaim Brigade · Parshat Bamidbar

FROM THE EDITORIAL DESK

Editor's Note

A new air is moving through the brigade's battalions. The new *tironim* have entered the event — running under the searing sun of the Jordan Valley — while *Yonatan Battalion* has emerged from Lebanon after a long and intensive period of fierce fighting. One cycle enters, another rotates between operations — the natural movement of a brigade that renews itself every several months.

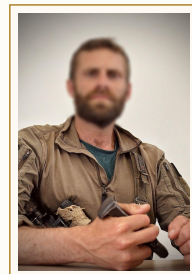
Parshat Bamidbar sets Israel each in their place, each beneath their banner. *Bnei Yisrael* underwent in the wilderness a long training meant to draw them out of the exile-consciousness of Egypt into a consciousness of conquering *Eretz Yisrael*.

Tironut is a kind of Israel's sojourn in the wilderness, while the warriors reenact Yehoshua's wars. For two millennia we read these parshiyot as belonging to the distant past. Today we merit to stand where our fathers stood. *Ashbreinu sh'zachinu!*

FROM THE COMMANDER

Commander's Word

Capt. H · Commander of Sayeret Hashmonaim



Dear warriors, commanders and readers of the bulletin, this Shabbat we begin the reading of *Chumash HaPekudim* — *Chumash Bamidbar* — which describes the long journey of Klal Yisrael toward the Promised Land. A familiar and pressing question arises: **why did the Holy One choose to give us the Torah specifically in the wilderness?** Why not wait until we entered *Eretz Yisrael*, or alternatively, give the Torah in a more comfortable, fertile and pleasant place?

Toras HaChassidus grants us a deep perspective. The wilderness symbolizes a low, spiritually desolate place — an arid place that has no water (and indeed “*ein mayim ela Torah*”) and is full of dangers like the “*nachash, saraf v'akrav*.”

The choice to grant the Torah in such a place teaches us an enormous foundation: the Torah does not belong, nor does it operate, only in places of high spiritual stature. It is not limited to the walls of the *beit midrash* or the halls of the yeshiva. The Torah was given in the wilderness to prove it penetrates and acts even in the “lowest” and most challenging places.

For us, the warriors of *Sayeret Hashmonaim*, this message lives within our operational reality. We often find ourselves in our own “wildernesses” — in ambushes on darkened nights, in mud and cold, in places far from the comfort of home or the holiness of the shul. Precisely there, out of *sblichut* and the brotherhood of warriors, we continue the moment of *Har Sinai* — proving that our Torah and *emunah* do not stop at the gate of the base. *Shabbat shalom u'mevorach!*

A Word of *Blessing*

TO THE BRIGADE

To the *tironim* who entered the event this week, to the warriors of *Yonatan Battalion* emerging from Lebanon, and to every soldier and commander — go from strength to strength, with *siyata d'Shmaya*.

— The Editorial Board

FROM THE TABLES OF THE
GEDOLEI YISRAEL

One's Place, *One's* Banner

HaRav HaTzaddik Rabbi Elimelech Biderman shlita



HaRav Elimelech
Biderman shlita

In *Parshat Bamidbar* the Torah sets out the order of the tribes with their banners. The tzaddikim explained that this parshah comes to root in us pure faith in our Father in Heaven — that all takes place by precise *hashgachah pratis*, the Creator arranging each one's place and “banner” according to the supernal intent.

Many say: “If I had Yankel's talent, I'd learn more; if I had Chatzkel's money, I'd support widows and orphans...” But the Holy One in His great goodness gave each one precisely what is right for his purpose and his precise place in the world.

CANDLE LIGHTING · EREV SHABBAT BAMIDBAR · 27 IYAR 5786 · LIGHT / HAVDALAH

Jerusalem · 6:48 / 8:07

Tel Aviv · 6:51 / 8:09

Bnei Brak · 6:51 / 8:09

New York · 7:43 / 8:50

Lakewood · 7:42 / 8:49

Miami · 7:41 / 8:36

Los Angeles · 7:33 / 8:38

Chicago · 7:40 / 8:47

Toronto · 8:14 / 9:23

London · 8:28 / 9:51

Paris · 8:46 / 10:11

Antwerp · 8:54 / 10:19

A QUESTION IN THE CAMP

A Question in the Camp



Maj. Rabbi Moshe Korkos
Brigade Rabbi · a farewell column

Q. *Kvod HaRav*, we understand that the Rav is parting from us. I wanted first of all to say thank you for the long period in which we merited the Rav, and for all the light the Rav cast on us over these past two years, since the founding of the brigade. As we approach this farewell — which falls precisely on the day of *Chag Mattan Torah*, may it come upon us for the good — we would be grateful if the Rav could give us *chizuk* on Torah learning, which is something I need to strengthen in. *Chag HaShavuot* reminds me how much my *neshamah* needs *k'viut ittim* every single day, but I need a word of *chizuk* on the matter. *Yasher koach*.

A. *Shalom, tzaddik*. First of all, you've moved me. It is a great privilege to serve in this holy brigade, and especially to see the processes from their very beginning and to see where the brigade has reached, *b'ezras Hashem*. This is an enormous merit. Let us not forget that first among the foundations are the dear commanders who serve in our brigade. Indeed we have merited — and of course, the heart of the matter is the warriors, for whose sake we are here.

As to your question, our Rabbis in the *Gemara* wrote for us: "*Divrei Torah tzrichin chizuk*" (*Berachot* 32b). And indeed, in order to succeed in Torah learning, all of us must strive for consistency and strengthening in learning — and this is not always easy.

First, sometimes we mistakenly think that Torah learning is measured by quantity — for example, how many *dafim* I covered or how many hours I sat. *L'aniyut da'ati*, the secret of *k'viut ittim* in learning is *stability*. By the nature of things, especially in the army, it's a bit complex for learning to be stable and with concentration — particularly in our generation, when each of us receives a daily flood of information and the head isn't always focused. How can one learn? (*Shavuot* is coming — a whole night straight...) What's the tip?

Our Sages in several places recall the piercing question a person is asked in the *beit din shel ma'alah*: "*Kava'ia ittim laTorah?*" (*Shabbat* 31b). The Creator of the world knows the trials and complexities each of us has. He demands chiefly *k'viut*. Once we've come into the *beit midrash*, let us try as much as possible to learn with focus and consistency to the best of our ability — even ten minutes! The moment we define for ourselves that the first ten minutes of the learning hour are iron-clad, it will be much easier to continue. The great difficulty is usually in the first minutes of the learning hour; after we've already entered the learning, the continuation runs with *stiyata d'Shmaya*.

Shlomo HaMelech says in *Mishlei*: "*Asbrei adam shomei'a li, lisbkod al daltotai yom yom...*" (8:34). Torah learning is a privilege not everyone merits, and therefore we need to exploit the merit that in the brigade there is a learning hour on the schedule.

Aleh v'hatzlach. May we all merit to receive the Torah in joy and from within true unity! Shabbat shalom u'mevorach!



YESHIVISHE IN THE FIELD

Yeshivishe in the Field



Mendi Gefni

The situation: Two tironim in "advanced training" — Mendi (Chabadnik) and Nachman (Breslover) — at a quiet guard post.

Mendi

"Nachman, the Rebbe says we're supposed to turn every place into 'Eretz Yisrael.' But how much 'birur nitzotzos' can you really do inside a Namer full of soot and diesel?"

Mendi

"By us we look for 'pnimiyus.' I try to think Chassidus while running, but my mind stops at 'Binah' and my body stays at 'Asiyah' somewhere behind, at the foot of the hill."

Mendi

"In the end it's about *sblichus*. Yesterday when I handed out cookies to the chevreh, I saw how 'u'faratzta' works even in the mud. The light pushes away all this exhaustion."

SONG OF THE WARRIOR

Song of the Warrior

By Cpl. M.M.

Between the Shtender and the Misder

*A pale light of dawn — not on the page of Gemara,
This time it is the horizon's line, leaping toward the news.
Just yesterday still "Ketzos" and "Nesivos," deep pilpul till the light,
And today — heavy boots, and uniform in the color of freedom.*

*The fingers that turned between Rashi and Tosafot,
Now grasp the weapon, with movements slightly hesitant.
The voice that climbed the rungs of the sugya, in a melody of ascent,
Now shouts "Hakshev!" between dunes and hills.*

*Trying to keep the pace within the platoon's pulse,
But the heart is still there, inside that very silence.
Between one order and the next, some daf echoes within me,
And even when the body is in the mud, the neshamah reaches for the shelf.*

*The tzitzit flutters from under the shoulder strap,
Whispering to me there is no contradiction here, only another mission.
Guarding the home, the Torah, the people,
Doing "retzon konecha" — even in sweat and blood.*

*This is not another world, this is the very same war,
Against the yetzer, against the enemy, for the sake of that very same
neshamah.*

*Only this time the service is in uniform and rifle,
May it be His will that Shechinah rest upon the work of our hands in love.*

Nachman

"Achbi, Rebbe Nachman says 'ein shum yi'ush.' Even when you're stuck in an ambush and the squad commander looks like the biggest *meni'ah* in the world — it's all one big *hisbodedus*. You, the Borei, and the vest."

Nachman

"Drop the chakiro! Just give a shout from the heart. When the samal hollers 'Zmanim!', I don't hear a samal — I hear a voice calling me to wake from the sleep of galus. It's all a matter of *ratzon*!"

Nachman

"Asbrecha! Yalla, get your gear in order. Here comes the platoon commander to check alertness — and looks like he's about to give us 'Tikkun Chatzos' over the morning mad'samim."

Field summary: One searches for the light, the other searches for the joy — and both wait for the "geulah" of the hour of tash.



FACES THAT TELL A STORY

Sgt. Eliyahu Moshe-Shlomo Tzimblist ז"ל

Eliyahu was born in the United States. When he was two, his family made *aliyah* to the city of Beit Shemesh, where he grew up and was educated.

From a young age he stood out for an unusual talent at building in wood — from swings and benches to cabinets and large pieces of furniture. He made *shtenders*, partitions and panels for the *aron kodesh* of the neighborhood shul. Friends recall that he knew how to fix anything quickly and skillfully — quietly and modestly, without seeking recognition. A line he used to say captured his way: “Don’t wait for people to ask you for help — just help.”

Eliyahu learned at Yeshivat “Ahavat Yisrael,” and afterward at the Hesder Yeshiva “Sha’alvim.” He was a smiling, warm-hearted bachur who knew how to make every person feel at home.

On 3 November 2022 he enlisted in Tzahal and served as a combat soldier in the Combat Engineering Corps, in the 601st Battalion of the “*Ikvot HaBarzel*” Formation (401). For him, the service was a true *shlichut*. He volunteered first for every mission, became deeply bonded to his comrades-in-arms, and his commanders saw in him a professional and devoted warrior — a person you could rely on in any situation.

On every leave from the army he would return to his beloved yeshiva, out of true longing for Torah learning. He dreamed that after his discharge he would return to the *beit midrash*, and later study building engineering to work in construction.

When the war broke out on 7 October, Eliyahu was in the middle of his training course. After he finished it, in December 2023, he entered Gaza with his battalion.

Throughout the months of fighting he was careful to reassure his family. Each time he was asked how he was, he would answer simply: “Everything is excellent, *baruch Hashem*.” And when his parents would say they were worried, he would add: “Don’t worry about me. Worry about the hostages, about more important things.”

On 9 Sivan 5784 (15 June 2024), during operational activity in the Tel Sultan neighborhood of Rafah, an anti-tank missile was fired at the Namer in which Eliyahu and seven other warriors were riding. All eight warriors were killed at the scene.

“We will miss you forever,” his family wrote after his fall. “We will never forget you, and we pray that the whole world will also not forget your light and your kindness.”

🕯️ *Y’bi zichro baruch — t’bi nishmato tz’rurah b’tzror ba’chayim* 🕯️

A GLIMPSE INTO THE PARSHAH

A Glimpse into the Parshah



Rabbi Yehuda Pevarsky
Senior Officer for Guidance & Policy

The parshah opens with the counting of Klal Yisrael in the wilderness. On the face of it, the Torah could have simply given the total number — yet the Torah descends to particulars: each tribe, each family, each individual is counted on his own.

Rashi brings: “Out of His love for them, He counts them at every moment.” The Holy One counts Klal Yisrael out of love and importance. We can sometimes feel like “just one of all,” but the Torah teaches that every Jew is a whole world. Each one has his unique *shlichut*, special powers, and a role no one else can fulfill in his place.

Even in the wilderness — a place of difficulty and challenge — Klal Yisrael was built precisely through order, responsibility and standing together around the mission. So too with us: a soldier who goes out on a mission from a place of Torah, *emunah* and *shlichut* brings a special power measured not only in physical strength but also in spiritual strength.

Chazal say: “*Ish al diglo b’otot*” — each tribe had its banner, its color and its uniqueness, but all together were part of one camp of Klal Yisrael.

So too in the Hashmonaim Brigade: each one comes from a different background, a different style and a different community, but all of us act together for one goal — to guard Klal Yisrael out of *kiddush Shem Shamayim*.

In conclusion, we wish to bless and offer great thanks to the outgoing Brigade Rabbi, **HaRav Moshe Korkos**, for a tenure of doing, devotion and accompaniment of soldiers and commanders with a shining face, responsibility and faith. We wish him very great success in his next role — may he continue to spread Torah, *kedushah* and good influence in every place he goes.

And we also bless the incoming Brigade Rabbi, **HaRav Betzael Givoni**, with blessing for success and abundant *siyata d’Shmaya*. May it be His will that he merit to lead the brigade, to strengthen the world of Torah among the soldiers, and to see great blessing in all the work of his hands. *Shabbat shalom u’mevorach*.

SHTEIGING IN THE BRIGADE

Shteiging in the Brigade



Rabbi Pinchas Yosef Akraw
Camp / Brigade Beit Midrash

When *Gdud Yonatan* was formed this year, it was stationed at Camp Keren in the Golan Heights. From the outset, three weeks before the battalion’s entry, a “vanguard force” from the battalion arrived to prepare the base as the home of the battalion’s warriors.

As is well known, wherever the Hashmonaim soldiers set foot, the first thing they build is a firm infrastructure of Torah learning. The battalion Rabbi, **HaRav Aryeh Rubinstein**, sought to strengthen the Torah-learning *sedarim* of the vanguard force, and arranged three tactical-equipment vouchers, 500 NIS each, for a raffle among those who came to learn. Every hour of learning earned the learner one raffle ticket.

In the end the raffle was held — and the one who won it was an *Ag”m* officer.

Anyone who understands a little about the complexity of staff work knows that the *Ag”m* officer is the busiest man on staff — on whose shoulders rests the full responsibility for coordinating and planning all the unit’s trainings and activities. This very *Ag”m* officer (B.K.) would rise every morning at five in order to engage in Torah, learning *Gemara* as part of *Daf HaYomi*. Like the early *tzaddikim*, he learns every morning for one hour before *tefillah* — iron! He doesn’t budge from his commitment to *k’viut ittim*; he knows that from the moment after *Shacharit* he will be sunk in the work of the battalion, so he dedicated the morning to the “business” of Torah in quality — this aside from closing the day in the night hours with additional learning *b’chavruta*.

By the way — he refused to accept the prize he had won, saying he prefers to be a servant who attends his master not in order to receive a reward.

These are the officers of Hashmonaim — true bnei Torah!



BRIGADE NEWS

Brigade *News*

Capt. Simcha Rosenberg
Brigade Spokesperson

Monthly “Yeshiva Day” in the Brigade

This past Thursday, the *Bahad* was painted in a distinctly yeshiva atmosphere. The monthly “*Yom HaYeshiva*” was dedicated entirely to rising in Torah — with in-depth learning *sedarim*, *shiurim* and *chizuk* talks — as part of the unique character of the brigade.

This day expresses the deep understanding that the strength of the Hashmonaim soldier lies in the combination between spiritual *shteiging* and military professionalism. Even in the heart of the operational system, Torah is the center of life and the central engine of activity.

Alongside the learning, the warriors enjoyed moments of bonding, a festive barbecue, and filming for the new Brigade Anthem production — moments of unity that give strength for the road ahead.

Operational Refresh: Gathering Strength for What Lies Ahead

After an intensive period of fighting and significant operational activity in the Lebanon sector, the battalion came out for a short respite. In recent times the warriors stood at the front: in scans, in locating and destroying terror infrastructure, and in face-to-face encounters with the enemy — all while maintaining meticulous adherence to the Chareidi way of life.

The refresh now is a necessary refueling station for gathering strength, ahead of the coming missions awaiting the warriors in the various sectors.



End of the reservist company training course · Photo: Brigade Spokesperson

IDF NEWS



Sgt. Yoel El Natan
Compiler

- ❖ After six years of legal proceedings, the military court convicted the terrorist who killed **Sgt. Amit Ben Yigal** during operational activity in the village of Ya'abad in 2020. The IDF emphasized that the defense establishment will continue to act with determination to bring to justice anyone who harms IDF soldiers or Israeli civilians.
- ❖ In southern Lebanon, IDF forces continue to enforce the terms of the ceasefire and to act against terror infrastructure of the Hezbollah organization. According to defense officials, more than 90 terror infrastructures have been destroyed, including weapons depots, structures and positions used for observation.
- ❖ In the Gaza Strip too, targeted activity continues against terror infrastructure and armed cells. In recent days, several terrorists identified as immediate threats to IDF forces operating on the ground were eliminated.
- ❖ Meanwhile, a report published in *The Wall Street Journal* claimed that, ahead of the war with Iran, Israel had established a military base in the desert in Iraq for assistance and rescue purposes. Israel did not deliver an official response to the publication.



Sgt. Amit Ben Yigal z"l

IDF LINGO

IDF *Lingo*

KAMBATZ (*Ktzin Mivtza'im*) — Operations Officer. Responsible for planning and managing the operational activity of the unit — everything connected to the schedule, missions and coordination. ❖ **RALASH** (*Rosh Lisbkab*) — Chief of Bureau. Manages the bureau of a commander or senior officer; coordinates the calendar, meetings and the organizational work around him.



FROM A WARRIOR'S DIARY

From a Warrior's *Diary**A Recruit at the Bahad*

This is the second week. If in the first week we were still in a kind of shock — from the uniforms, from the distance, from the thought that “*here, it’s really happening*” — the second week is the week in which the dust begins to settle, and reality begins to be built.

I look around me in the hallway of the barracks and see the faces. These aren’t just the faces of friends from the study-hall bench or from the neighborhood; these are the faces of the people in whose hands, in a few months, I will place my life — and they will place theirs in mine. There is something in this intensity, in this connection that is created without words, that simply cannot be explained to someone who stayed outside.

This week was not easy. The discipline, the precision in times, the standing on your feet when all you want is to sit a moment with a *sefer* or a cup of coffee in peace. But within that running, within that “*Ken HaMefaked*,” something amazing happens: we learn what it means to be part of something greater than ourselves.

Sometimes, when I stand in *chatzi goren* and look up at the skies of the *Bahad*, I think about the name of our brigade. *Hashmonaim*. This is not just a brand. This is an inheritance. We are not here to become something else — we are here to be the fighting version of who we are. We bring with us *tefillab*, the spirit, the values from home, and pour them into the iron of the weapon and the dust of the field.

At nights, when finally the lights go out, there is a moment of quiet. That is the moment when the longing for home floats up a little, the thought of the coming *Shabbat* or of the family. But then I remember why I came here. I came to prove that one can — and must — be both: both Chareidi who keeps the light as the heavy, and a professional warrior who doesn’t give himself a millimeter.

The second week in *tironut* is the week when we stop being “new inductees” and start being “soldiers.” We’re not there yet — the road is still long — but the first steps are already plowed in the earth of the *Bahad*.

Chevre, lift your heads. We are writing history here, even if right now it looks like just another day of standing in the schedule. We are Hashmonaim soldiers — that is the greatest pride of our generation.

A STORY FOR SHABBAT

A Story for *Shabbat*

Capt. Rabbi Aryeh Rubinstein
Rabbi of Gdud Yonatan

The first *Rashi* in our parshah speaks of how, out of the Holy One’s great love for us, He “*counts us every hour*.” How much we must strengthen in *abavat Yisrael*.

The Baron Rothschild held a *Kiddusha Rabbah* for all the inhabitants of the city, on the occasion of a special *simchah* in his home. When everyone arrived at the magnificent hall, they were astonished to see that there was no food — only goblets and bottles of wine. While everyone was trying to understand what was going on, the Baron entered, took the goblet in his hand, made *Kiddush* over the wine, and immediately afterward made “*Borei minei mezonot*” and ate the goblet. It turned out that special cakes had been prepared in the shape of a goblet — a flourish of the Baron in honor of the occasion.

At the place of honor sat the *Gaon* Rabbi Chaim Ozer Grodzinski *zt”l*, and the Baron honored him to make *Kiddush* again to exempt all the assembled. The Grach”O delayed several minutes, and only afterward did he too make *Kiddush* over the wine and eat the goblet.

Afterward several Jews approached the Grach”O and asked the Rav why he had not made *Kiddush* immediately. The *tzaddik* answered them: From the strict letter of the law it was a problem to make *Kiddush* before covering the *mezonot* — presumably a challenging matter in this situation. On the other hand, if I did not make *Kiddush*, the Baron would surely be embarrassed by this. Then I thought to myself that the source of this *halacha* stems from “*so that the bread will not see its shame*.” If so, the matter is simple and clear that it is certainly preferable to embarrass the bread than to embarrass a Jew, *chas v’shalom*!

GUEST COLUMN

Guest *Column*

Rabbi Yedidya Koven · R”M of Yehuda Company, Yonatan Battalion

The Hashmonai is faithful to the G-d of Israel. Therefore:

- The *Hashmonai* is ready to give even his soul for the sanctity of His Name, His Torah, His people and His land.
- The *Hashmonai* continues the chain of *Hashmonaim* and zealots who have lowered the horn of Israel’s enemies throughout the generations.
- The *Hashmonai* enlists in the wars of Hashem and scorns cowardice.
- The *Hashmonai* does not surrender before the weak nor before those who mock him in his service of *yisbarach*.
- The *Hashmonai* is firm and restores the crown of valor and Jewish pride.
- The *Hashmonai* obeys without challenge the *halacha* and the orders of his commanders.
- The *Hashmonai* bears with pride being a *ben Torah* and loving every Jew.
- The *Hashmonai* directs his deeds *l’shem Shamayim* and serves as a model to all in his conduct and in his *middot*.
- The *Hashmonai* represents the army of Israel, and in particular the Chareidi brigade, without fear.
- The *Hashmonai* demonstrates and reflects in his appearance and in his dress a high spiritual standard.
- The *Hashmonai* awaits the coming of *Mashiach*, and longs for the establishment of *Malchut Yisrael* and the building of the *Beit HaMikdash*.



LIFE IN THE BRIGADE

Life *in the Brigade*

Yochanan Chayot (Chayot) · Incoming Company R”M

Q Tell us about yourself.

My name is Yochanan Chayot (Chayot), 36, married plus four children, *b’li ayin bara*. My father *mori* is **HaRav Baruch Chayot shlita**, Rosh Yeshivat Maarava, and a well-known figure in the world of education. He is also a composer and creator, and many of his songs are *nichsei tzon barzel* of the Jewish people (such as “*Kol Ha’Olam Kulo*,” “*Mi Ha’ish*,” “*Lo Amut Ki Echye*,” and more). I learned at Yeshiva Gedolah Mir, and got married. I became an R”M at Yeshivat Maarava and a “*Sho’el U’Meshiv*” at another yeshiva in Moshav Matityahu. I taught Torah all day.

Q How did you come to the brigade?

A combination of circumstances led me to it. The Seventh of October gave me a great awakening to understand that we cannot live in a bubble and cannot be disconnected from what is happening here in the Land to our people. I saw firsthand my brother who is in *miluim* in the Alexandroni Brigade — hundreds of days far from family and home — and I saw how his wife and children deal with it. The cry of the verse “*Shall your brothers go out to war and you sit here?*” grated on me very deeply. How could I sit at home while my brother gives himself for the people? I was certainly doing *shlichut* and teaching, but it felt to me that something was lacking in me, at least personally. Then I learned of the Hashmonaim Brigade, through my dear brother-in-law HaRav Aryeh Rubinstein *hy”v*, who began as a soldier in the *miluim* track of the first cycle, and today serves as Rabbi of Yonatan Battalion in the brigade. I heard from him and from a few others about the possibility of enlisting as a soldier, and decided I was joining as a soldier. *Baruch Hashbem*, I merited to finish combat training, was a squad leader there, and I don’t regret it for a moment. They wanted me to continue to the *Machimim* course, but it was hard to continue right after training to *Machim* — right now I need a bit of a respite. Perhaps later I’ll come back as a *Mem-Kaf*. In any case, I’ll soon return to the brigade as a company R”M in the battalion, and we’ll see what comes next.

Q Tell us about the transition from being an R”M in yeshiva to being a recruit in combat training.

Oof... first of all, it’s a great lesson in humility and lowness of spirit. I’m 36, and I receive orders from someone 20 years old who puts me at “*matzav sbtayim*” and runs me back and forth because some small thing wasn’t exactly up to standard... You have to lower the head and understand that there’s a bigger event going on here, and keep in mind the great vision of “why I’m here” — and not get stuck in those small moments that can humiliate and feel unpleasant. When you understand the reason and the context, it gives strength. But it was certainly a powerful experience. I felt I received an enormous amount from it personally, and I felt *shlichut* at every moment. It was clear to me what we are doing here — both at the general level, to bear the yoke with one’s fellow with Klal Yisrael, and specifically the *shlichut* we are doing in the brigade. I knew and felt how much we are doing something historic for Klal Yisrael. I very much believe we can make a deep change — that our public too, for whom this is relevant of course, will take responsibility for Klal Yisrael, and that we will be partners in this immense mitzvah of “*nosei b’ol im chavero*” and “*lo ta’amod al dam re’echa*.” May we merit to do this in *kedushah* and in *tabarah*.

Q You speak about bearing the yoke with one’s fellow — this week you released a song on that theme.

Indeed. I’ve been engaged in music for several years, but this week I released a song I had the privilege of writing during training. It expresses what we’re doing here in

the brigade — that partnership, putting down the desire always to be right, listening, and trying to connect with one another. The line “*B’or Panecha lo neida od milchamah*” refers to our inner wars. Throughout our history Klal Yisrael has continually fallen on this. If we merit true peace from within, we won’t know war one to another — and then we won’t have wars from outside either.

Q How would you summarize the experience in the brigade?

We started only a year and a half ago, and it’s still a kind of pilot. But I see that we’re on a positive trend and that this is really going in the right direction. There is what to improve and fix — nothing is perfect from the first moment. But it is agreed upon among all of us that there is an inner spirit of *kedushah* pulsing inside the *Bahad*, something beyond merely technical. We feel here a deeper *shlichut* in what we are doing. There is a sense that something very big is happening here in the right direction. It is a great privilege to be a partner in this doing. The meticulousness on *tefillot*, on the learning hour, the very concept of company R”Mim — which is what I’m going to do, men of *chinuch* who are with the *chevreh*, with their hand on the pulse of every bachur, where he is, adapting the learning to his level — this is truly a yeshiva inside Tzahal.

Q A yeshiva inside Tzahal? Not an overstated phrase?

I’m full of hope it won’t be exaggerated at all. A young bachur who comes into the *Bahad* is — one way or another — being educated to something. If we don’t take initiative and bequeath the pure *hashkafah*, they will be built in another way. From my perspective, unequivocally I see this as a yeshiva that is entirely *avodat Hashbem*.

Q As a company R”M, what message would you want to convey to the soldier?

I’m specifically going to be in the battalion and not in the *Bahad*. From the experience I managed to taste a little on the Lebanon border for a few weeks, going in and out for activities, I understood that life in the battalion is much more of a mess. The schedule is much less ordered, the learning hour is not always orderly, and naturally a soldier with disorganized times somewhat loses himself. I think one of the things that’s very important to bequeath is that the soldier should know that even if the schedule isn’t very orderly, and he doesn’t pray *l’chatchilah* at the right time, and he doesn’t have an orderly learning hour — he should know that he is in the framework of *avodat Hashbem*. That everything he is doing is *kodesh*. Don’t let him feel about himself, “*vai*, I’ve fallen, I’m not in the schedule, I’m no longer who I once was...” No. This is your *shlichut* now — these are the circumstances you’re in, and you need to take the light you have within this place and rejoice in it, grow in it. Now this is your *avodat Hashbem*.

Q A special moment you remember from training?

Just last week, at the ceremony marking the end of training. Since the war with Iran prevented the original beret march at the *Kotel*, they did a make-up march for us — with the families — and we arrived at the *Kotel HaMa’aravi* at the end. That moment took me back to our first week of training, when they brought us to watch the closing ceremony of the cycle before us; and I’ll tell you the truth, I had my doubts I would make it. Standing opposite the *Kotel* last week, remembering those thoughts — we did it. It was surreal. It gave me belief that with a goal, a vision and the will, one can succeed — even at this age.



JOURNEY IN TIME

Journey in Time



Maj. Yitzchak Barkai
Brigade Education Officer

Sha'ar HaGai — The Passage to the Mountain

The Memory within the Joy

This week we mark the day on which we merited to return to the *Kotel HaMa'aravi* and to the Old City of Jerusalem. It is only fitting toward our chain of generations to pause and, in the moment of joy, recall those who sowed in tears. "*Ha'zor'im b'dim'ab, b'rinah yiktzoru.*" The reapers of 5727 reaped seeds that had been sown over two thousand years of exile. Everyone who said "*L'shanah Ha'ba'ah b'Yerushalayim*" and did not merit. Everyone who gave his soul on the way to Jerusalem throughout the generations. All the dreamers who died in foreign lands with their faces eastward — they are all the sowers. The paratroopers at the *Kotel* were the final reapers. And as is known, "*a mitzvah is named only after the one who completes it.*"

And not by chance, the 28th of Iyar is also the memorial day for the Jews of Ethiopia who perished on their way to the Land. Perhaps to teach us that there cannot be the "*rinah of the reapers*" without the "*tear of the sowers.*" The Jews of Ethiopia crossed the deserts of Sudan on their way to Jerusalem out of an eternal yearning, two thousand years old, that pushed and continues to push all of us toward that same Zion-point in Jerusalem. Many of them remained on the way. And when we, their continuers, walk today in Jerusalem, we are continuing the lives of seeds sown in tears in the Sudanese desert.

The Neck Between the Lowlands and the Mountain

During the drive up to Jerusalem, in one moment the landscape changes. The level lowlands remain behind, and the mountains begin to close in from every side. We know this passage by the seemingly mundane name "*Mechalef Sha'ar HaGai.*" But to anyone who listens to the echoes rising up from between the rocks, it is clear that this is not just another stretch of road.

The historical and spiritual struggle over the way to Jerusalem is woven also into the geographical structure of the Land. The topography changes markedly at the meeting between the lowland region and the central mountain ridge. The free spaces of movement on the plain are channeled into narrow valleys. The most prominent of them is *Sha'ar HaGai*, which functions both geographically and conceptually similar to the human neck. Just as the heart pumps the blood and pushes it upward to the head through the narrow passage of the neck, so the movement is channeled from the broad lowlands into the valley, in order to ascend to the "head" — Jerusalem. The ascent to the mountain requires a physical passage through a narrow place.

Because of its being "a necessary passage," the space of connection between the lowlands and the mountain has from time immemorial been a strategic focus. In this space, *Yehoshua bin Nun* commanded "*Shemesh b'Givon dom, v'yarei'ach b'Emek Ayalon,*" and at *Sha'ar HaGai* he pursued the five kings as they fled to the cave at Makedah, near Beit Shemesh. Later, in the battle of Emmaus, Yehuda the Maccabee shrewdly exploited the terrain to strike the enemy camp — a victory that was a critical milestone in clearing the way for the purification of the Mikdash. Generations later, in the War of Independence (5708), *Bab el-Wad* became a symbol of the struggle for Klal Yisrael's connection to its capital, Jerusalem — here the supply convoys entered the pass again and again under fire to break through the blockades and stream air into the cut-off city. The rusting armored vehicles standing to this day at the roadside are not a monument — they are the seeds from which Jerusalem as we know it today grew.

The Sowers and the Reapers

Jerusalem of 5727 grew from two thousand years of tears. The paratroopers at the *Kotel* drew their strength from the fighters of 5708 who struggled for Klal Yisrael's connection to Jerusalem, from the prayers of the Jews of Sefarad, from the longings of the Chassidim of Poland, and from the singing of the Mekubalim in Tzfat. All of them sowed. They did not know that they would not reap. What we see today in the news is always either the fruit of a distant sowing, or a seed that will be reaped in generations to come. And this is the secret of Israeli history: our responsibility is only for the climbing itself, not for the question of whether we will see the summit.

To ascend in the valley. To cross the narrow place. To sow something — even in tears, even without knowing who will reap. Shabbat shalom!

A SOLDIER ON THE MAP

A Soldier on the Map



Elchanan Kidron
Age 20, from Beitar Illit · Yeshivat Wolfson, Bayit Vegan

Q What is your role here?

A combat soldier in training, in advanced training.

Q What is your *pakal*?

Squad leader — aspiring to be a commander, *b'ezras Hashem*.

Q What kind of commander do you want to be?

A commander who is a meaningful figure for his soldiers — humanly, in Torah and in professional matters.

Q What is it like being in the Hashmonaim Brigade?

Wow. I think it has matured me in many areas. It helped me a lot in my self-clarification. Of course it's also a challenge — the very fact of going outside the protective walls of the *beit midrash*. But as I said, it gives a lot of room for a great deal of personal work.

Q Personal growth in the brigade?

I've strengthened here in many things. For instance, in the learning hour — many times after a tiring day in the field, the learning hour comes around in the field, without many conditions, and I often manage to fight tooth and nail to sit and learn an hour properly, in the toil of Torah. It connects a lot.

Q What surprised you most in the Hashmonaim Brigade?

The amazing connection in the *beit midrash* between commanders and soldiers. In our platoon, for example, the commander and a few more guys organized a *shiur* in *Gemara* for everyone, and we learn together *b'shteigen* — and also from the *chavrutot* the commanders have among themselves; they are truly part of the *havayah* of the *beit midrash*.

Q A tough moment you experienced in training?

There were many, mostly in tough field weeks. You're after a few days in the field, sweaty and worn out. At moments like those I try to strengthen myself with the purpose for which I'm doing this.

Q A special moment you experienced in the brigade?

Last week we received the Infantry pin to our beret after a hard *masa*, and it made me reflect — wow, I am now joining generations of warriors and of Jews in every era who gave themselves and toiled greatly for great things and for Klal Yisrael.

Q What do you think about the future of the brigade?

I very much hope and invest in this being a great place for Hashem — a great place in Torah, in *avodat Hashem*, and a place that will enable in the best way possible those for whom this is the *avodat Hashem* suited to them.

Q A message you want to convey to your platoon?

(a) You are *totachim*, well done! And (b) all of us need to remember and strengthen in *re'ut*, in brotherhood and in helping one another — for that is truly what lifts us and gives us strength, and that is what helps us do what we are doing in the best possible way.



A BURNING CHASSIDIC SOLDIER

A Burning Chassidic *Soldier*

Cpl. Mendel Rota
Gdud Yonatan

That scene always amuses me. New *tironim* in their first weeks. I see them running, climbing up onto the rope for the first time, doing a few push-ups, and shouting “*Misparei barzel l’hitpaked.*” It takes me back. You can think how far back — only a year ago I finished training. But it feels like ten years back.

How I ran after some young commander who ran me back and forth to touch some wall. How I shouted strange phrases while doing twenty push-ups. *Avadim hayinu.* What a period, *achi.*

But in the last two months, my whole company has been in Lebanon. They’ve done crazy work — purged whole areas of the enemy, cleaned out weapons stockpiles, captured terrorists. And I think of all these new *tironim*: in another six months or so they’ll be there too. Becoming real warriors. Gaza, Lebanon, Syria, Yehuda and Shomron. Taking responsibility for our state.

How much every little thing in *tironut* teaches you for life. I’m reminded of my “period of forgetfulness” — I kept forgetting the weapon in the room. They shouted, they punished, but it took me time to feel the weapon as part of my hands. Or at the firing range — when my weapon once tilted a little to the side, I suddenly caught an enormous shout: “*Mendel!! Get out!!!*” I went red and white — the oldest of the bunch, walking out like a humiliated child. From that day on, I no longer moved the weapon by accident.

Today I walk with the weapon in the street, in full confidence. The hand on the stock — this is the weapon that protects me. I don’t forget it; no mistakes with such a tool. This is my baby. With this tool I defend my people wherever I go. With this tool I know how to neutralize a terrorist wherever I get to. With this tool I make *kiddush Hashem*, when people see a Chareidi soldier carrying his weapon with Jewish pride. All those shouts — they straightened out all the crookedness of my heart. “*Lo nivre’u re’amim ela l’fashet akmimiyut sheba’lev,*” says the *Gemara* in *Berachot*.

I’m telling this for the new *tironim*, who have suddenly landed inside the event. We, the first cycle, had no concept of what *tironut* was. As if I’d been tossed into some movie I had no idea what was happening in — while someone above me kept shouting at me what role I was supposed to play. That was the event.

But it won’t be long, and you’ll suddenly grasp what has grown within you during this short period. It looks like a lot of time but it really isn’t. Think about what you accomplished in the seven months before the army. You moved a little to the right and a little to the left, that’s all. You read maybe two books, met three new people, killed time. Now your time is exploited to the level of seconds. This is a period that will accompany you all your life.

Kitzer — what I came to say. It came out as a riff of a corporal getting carried away with himself, never mind — you are awfully sweet, and it’s moving to see you. You have the responsibility to shape the next Hashmonaim generation. Every cycle influences the cycle after it, just as you receive a lot from the tradition set here by the previous cycles. But we are still in the shaping stage. Take responsibility — shape the figure of the Hashmonaim warrior. We want to win this national mission we’ve taken upon ourselves. It’s we who will determine whether Hashmonaim succeeds or not. Go for it with all your strength. *Gut Shabbes.*

HALACHA IN THE ARMY

Halacha in the Army



Maj. Rabbi Eliezer Halperin
Brigade Posek

A Night Awake: The Implication for *Birchot HaTorah*

Q. On the night of *Chag HaShavuot* it is customary to remain awake all night in Torah learning. May one recite *Birchot HaTorah* the next morning as usual?

A.

The *Gemara* in *Berachot* (11b) states: “*Rav Yehuda said in the name of Shmuel: One who rose early to learn — before he recited Shema, he needs to bless; after he recited Shema, he doesn’t need to bless, because he was already exempted with Ahavah Rab-bah.*” What does one bless? Rav Yehuda in the name of Shmuel: “*Asher kideshanu b’mitzvotav v’tzivanu la’asok b’divrei Torah*”; Rabbi Yochanan adds: “*Ha’arev na...*”; Rav Hamnuna adds: “*Asher bachar banu mi’kol ha’amim v’natan lanu et torato. Baruch atah Hashem, notein ha’Torah.*” Rav Hamnuna said: This is the choicest of the blessings, therefore let us say them all.

The *Rosh* (*Berachot* 1:11) discusses: Until when does the blessing one made apply? He concludes that for people who are constantly engaged in Torah, and even when they go out to their affairs they hurry to attend to their needs in order to return to learn, and their mind is always on their learning — this is not considered an interruption. He adds that therefore one who learns at night doesn’t need to bless; conversely one who slept by day — this is an interruption and he needs to bless again. He also brings the opinion of *Rabbeinu Tam* that a daytime nap is not an interruption.

The *Shulchan Aruch* (47:11) rules: “*A fixed nap during the day on his bed is an interruption; and some say it is not an interruption, and so is the custom.*” The *Mishnah Berurah* there brings many *acharonim* who rule one should bless, and concludes that there is what to rely on for both customs.

The *Magen Avraham* explains: the *Tur* and the *Rosh* hold that everything depends on sleep; *Rabbeinu Tam* holds that the morning blessings were instituted because the Sages fixed this blessing for each day.

HaGaon Rav Asher Weiss sharpens that according to the *Tur* and the *Rosh*, *Birchot HaTorah* are of the type of *Birchot HaMitzvot* on the mitzvah of *Talmud Torah*, therefore dependent on “interruption.” By contrast, the view of *Rabbeinu Tam* is that these are blessings of praise, like *Birchot HaShachar*. The Gr”a (Rav Akiva Eiger) innovates that in the case where one slept by day and remained awake the whole night, all agree he is obligated in the blessing in the morning — and so ruled the *Mishnah Berurah* (s.k. 28).

SUMMARY

“*One who is awake all night, according to the custom of many of the Ashkenazim, should not recite Birchot HaTorah in the morning (and only if possible, one should fulfill them by hearing the blessings from someone else, or have intent to be exempted by the blessing of Ahavat Olam [Ahavah Rab-bah]), unless he had a fixed nap during the day (before that night or after it). The custom of the Sephardim is to recite the blessings, while the custom of the Yemenites and some of the Ashkenazim is to try to fulfill the blessing by hearing it from another; and when this is not possible, they bless themselves.*” (*Torat HaMachaneh*, ch. 4:4)

JOKES ASIDE

Jokes *Aside*

In tironut, the commander asks: “Who can tell me what an order is?”

A bachur raises his hand: “Something my mother used to say twice and Abba used to say once.”

A new tiron at the firing range whispers to his neighbor: “How do you remember the safety rules?”

His neighbor: “Simple — I imagine the mashgiach from yeshiva is standing right behind me.”